

Broadcasting

Anyone with access to a television or radio can now enjoy drama every day. Sometimes these are productions of works originally written for the stage, and adapted. More common are dramas specially written for broadcasting. Many of these are run as series, so that every week, or even every day, people can watch or listen to another episode of their favourite drama. Some forms of television drama have proved especially popular, such as crime stories, adventure series, and soap operas.

O Maraja, satirical Brazilian soap opera



Soap operas

Immensely popular, these serialized television dramas usually deal with the lives and loves of "ordinary" people. Soap operas are so-called because they were at first sponsored by commercial companies such as soap manufacturers.



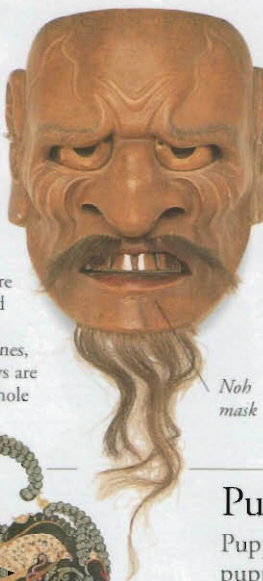
Chinese opera

Traditional Chinese, or Beijing, opera retells stories from historical events and Buddhist stories. The action comprises arias and recitations, mime, song, and dance, with music from an orchestra of traditional instruments, such as the lute, clappers, gongs, and drums.

Farewell My Concubine is a film about Chinese opera.

Noh theatre

In traditional Japanese Noh drama, actors wear elaborate costumes and masks, but perform on a bare stage. They move slowly and make special, meaningful gestures. They chant their lines, accompanied by music. Plays are performed in groups, the whole programme lasting an entire day.



Noh mask

World drama

Many non-Western cultures have produced their own, distinct traditions of drama, which draw on local conditions and skills. In Asia, for example, drama draws on local mythology and tales of gods and goddesses. Such drama also uses local craft skills to produce striking costumes and masks, and may be accompanied with music played on traditional instruments.

Noh masks represent five groups: male, female, old people, the gods, and monsters.

Ritual drama

In parts of Africa, Asia, and Melanesia, traditional drama forms an important part of religious ritual. A high priest or shaman puts on a mask and costume that completely disguises him and, as he dances to music, people believe that he actually becomes the spirit he is imitating.



Papua New Guinea Trobrianders: ritual religious drama.

Actors

The skill of the actors is vital to the success of a drama. Using the right tone of voice, facial expression, or gesture, an actor creates the illusion that the audience is watching or listening to real people and events on stage or screen. Many actors study at drama school before becoming professionals, paid to appear on stage.



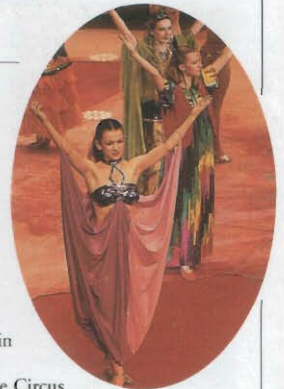
Drama festivals

Drama festivals are held around the world so that theatre-goers can celebrate the best in acting and writing. Plays range from traditional productions to experimental works from new writers. The Edinburgh International Festival, held annually, is world famous.

At a festival held each year in Salzburg, Austria, actors re-enact a medieval religious drama.

Circuses

A circus is a form of entertainment that combines a number of different skills, such as juggling, acrobatics, clowning, and conjuring. Circuses date from the end of the 18th century. Animal acts once formed part of circus routines, but these are now less popular in the West.



Moscow State Circus

Javanese shadow puppet



In shadow plays, puppets are used to tell traditional stories.

Made from leather

The operator uses thin rods to move the puppet.

Puppetry

Puppetry is a type of drama involving puppets, figures that seem to come to life when a human operator moves them. It is one of the oldest types of drama, dating from at least the 5th century BC. One example is shadow puppetry, which is popular in Southeast Asia. A light is used to cast a shadow of the puppet onto a translucent viewing screen. The puppet then acts out a play.

Timeline

5th century BC The Greeks pioneer tragedy and comedy.

11th to 15th centuries AD Religious drama becomes popular in Europe.

Statue of comic actor from Roman drama



1580–1642 In England, the Elizabethan and Jacobean dramatists revitalize English drama.

1600–80 The Golden Age of Spanish drama.

1782 Friedrich von Schiller (1759–1805) stages *The Robbers*, one of the plays that inspires the German Romantic movement in the 18th century.

c.1800 In Vietnam, Hat Boi theatre dramatizes tales of war and suffering.

Late 1800s "Realist" drama develops, exploring modern social issues.

1960s The "Theatre of the Absurd" subverts the conventions of the theatre.

1990s Musicals are the most popular type of play.



Robert Lepage

The Canadian playwright and director Robert Lepage (b. 1957) has achieved world status for his experimental work. Giving everyday objects symbolic meaning, and working closely with actors, he has taken risks that, while not always a critical success, push back the boundaries of drama.

FIND OUT MORE

FESTIVALS

FILMS AND FILM-MAKING

GREECE, ANCIENT

LITERATURE

MEDIEVAL EUROPE

OPERA

RENAISSANCE

SHAKESPEARE

THEATRES